DEF-001

Defense mechanisms: what are they, in ego psychology?

DEF-002

Vaillant's maturity levels of defenses?

DEF-003

Repression?

DEF-004

Suppression?

DEF-005

Repression versus suppression?

DEF-006

Denial?

DEF-007

Projection?

DEF-008

Displacement?

DEF-002

Psychotic (e.g., delusional projection), immature (projection, acting out), neurotic or intermediate (repression, displacement, reaction formation), mature (sublimation, altruism, humor, suppression, anticipation).

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-001

Mostly unconscious ways the ego reduces anxiety from conflict between drives, conscience and reality. Systematized by Anna Freud; ranked by maturity by Vaillant.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense the ego and it...

DEF-004

Consciously choosing to set a worry aside until later. A mature defense, and the classic conscious one. Example: deciding to think about a diagnosis after a work deadline.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-003

Unconsciously keeping a distressing memory, feeling or wish out of awareness.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense repression

DEF-006

Refusing to accept an external reality that is too painful, such as insisting a terminal diagnosis is wrong despite clear evidence.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense denial

DEF-005

Repression is unconscious; suppression is a deliberate, conscious choice.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-008

Shifting a feeling from its real target to a safer one. Example: reprimanded at work, the client yells at a partner at home.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense displacement

DEF-007

Attributing one's own unacceptable feelings to someone else. Example: a client who is hostile insists the social worker is hostile. Common in paranoid thinking.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense projection

DEF-009

Displacement versus projection?

DEF-010

Reaction formation?

DEF-011

Sublimation?

DEF-012

Sublimation versus displacement?

DEF-013

Rationalization?

DEF-014

Intellectualization?

DEF-015

Rationalization versus intellectualization?

DEF-016

Isolation of affect?

DEF-010

Acting in a way opposite to an unacceptable impulse, such as being excessively sweet toward someone one resents. The behavior often looks exaggerated.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense reaction form...

DEF-009

Displacement changes the target of a feeling; projection changes who owns the feeling.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-012

Sublimation redirects an impulse into constructive, valued activity (mature). Displacement aims the feeling at a safer target (neurotic).

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-011

Channeling an unacceptable impulse into a socially valued activity, such as aggression into competitive sport. A mature defense.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-014

Using abstract analysis and facts to avoid feeling, such as discussing grief research instead of one's own grief.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense intellectualiza...

DEF-013

Offering a plausible but self-serving reason for a behavior or disappointment ('I didn't want that job anyway').

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-016

Describing a painful event in detail with no emotion attached, such as recounting an assault flatly.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-015

Rationalization makes excuses. Intellectualization retreats into analysis to keep feelings at a distance.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-017

Undoing?

DEF-018

Regression?

DEF-019

Acting out?

DEF-020

Splitting?

DEF-021

Projective identification?

DEF-022

Idealization and devaluation?

DEF-023

Identification with the aggressor?

DEF-024

Introjection?

DEF-018

Returning to behavior from an earlier stage under stress, such as bedwetting or baby talk after a sibling's birth.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense regression

DEF-017

An act meant to symbolically cancel an earlier act or thought, such as compulsively doing favors after an angry remark. Often seen with obsessive-compulsive patterns.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense undoing

DEF-020

Seeing self or others as all good or all bad. On treatment teams it can divide staff into 'good' and 'bad' helpers.

Kernberg, O. (1975). Borderline Conditions and Pathological Narcissism. J...

DEF-019

Expressing an unconscious impulse or feeling through action rather than words, often impulsive or harmful.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-022

Swinging between seeing someone as perfect and as worthless; common with splitting in borderline personality organization.

Kernberg, O. (1975). Borderline Conditions and Pathological Narcissism. J...

DEF-021

Projecting a disowned feeling onto someone and behaving so that the person comes to feel or act it. The worker may notice the induced feeling in themselves.

Klein, M. (1946). Notes on some schizoid mechanisms. International Jour...

DEF-024

Taking another person's values or qualities into oneself, such as a parent's harsh criticism becoming one's own inner voice.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense introjection

DEF-023

Taking on the traits or behavior of someone feared or abusive, which reduces one's sense of helplessness.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense identification...

DEF-025

Compensation?

DEF-026

Somatization?

DEF-027

Dissociation (as a defense)?

DEF-028

Passive aggression?

DEF-029

Altruism (as a defense)?

DEF-030

Humor (as a defense)?

DEF-031

Anticipation?

DEF-032

Fixation?

DEF-026

Psychological distress expressed as physical complaints.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-025

Overachieving in one area to make up for a perceived weakness in another.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-028

Expressing hostility indirectly, such as chronic lateness or procrastination toward someone one resents.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-027

A temporary break in awareness, memory or identity that shields a person from overwhelming distress.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-030

Facing painful feelings through humor without discomfort to oneself or others. A mature defense.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-029

Easing one's own distress by helping others in a way that brings real satisfaction. A mature defense.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-032

Remaining partly attached to an earlier developmental stage because of unresolved conflict there.

Freud, S. (1905). Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality Essay II: infanti...

DEF-031

Realistically planning for and emotionally preparing for future discomfort. A mature defense.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-033

A client lavishly praises a coworker who got the promotion the client wanted, but tenses whenever the coworker is named. Defense?

DEF-034

After a fight with a supervisor, a client kicks the family dog. Defense?

DEF-035

A client with a new cancer diagnosis keeps rescheduling oncology visits and says the tests were 'probably mixed up.' Defense?

DEF-036

A client says calmly, 'I'll worry about the layoffs after my exam on Friday.' Defense?

DEF-037

A client who was bullied for years becomes harshly controlling with younger coworkers. Defense?

DEF-038

Why do defenses matter in practice?

DEF-039

Projection versus projective identification?

DEF-040

Splitting on a treatment team: best response?

DEF-034

Displacement: anger moved to a safer target.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense displacement

DEF-033

Reaction formation: exaggerated friendliness covering resentment.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense reaction form...

DEF-036

Suppression: a conscious, deliberate postponement.

Vaillant, G. E. (1992). Ego Mechanisms of Defense: A Guide for Clinicians...

DEF-035

Denial: refusing to accept a painful reality.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense denial

DEF-038

They show how a client manages anxiety. With fragile clients, support adaptive defenses rather than strip them away.

Goldstein, E. G. (1995). Ego Psychology and Social Work Practice (2nd ed...

DEF-037

Identification with the aggressor.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense identification...

DEF-040

Staff communicate often, hold one consistent plan, and avoid being cast as all-good or all-bad helpers.

Kernberg, O. (1975). Borderline Conditions and Pathological Narcissism. J...

DEF-039

Projection only attributes the feeling to another person. Projective identification also pressures that person into feeling or acting it out.

Klein, M. (1946). Notes on some schizoid mechanisms. International Jour...

DEF-041

Denial versus repression?

DEF-042

Countertransference versus a client's defense?

DEF-042

Countertransference is the worker's emotional reaction to the client. A defense is the client's own way of managing anxiety. Don't confuse the two.

Freud, S. (1912). The dynamics of transference transference and counter...

DEF-041

Denial blocks awareness of an external reality; repression blocks awareness of an internal thought, feeling or memory.

Freud, A. (1936). The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defense denial; repres...